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Employment status, unemployment duration, and health-related metrics among US adults of prime working age: Behavioral Risk Factor Surveillance System, 2018–2019

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Abstract

Background: While unemployment has been associated with poor health, few recent studies in the United States have comprehensively assessed associations between employment status (including duration unemployed) and healthcare access, health-related behaviors, and specific health outcomes.

Methods: We assessed health-related metrics by employment status in 2018–2019 Behavioral Risk Factor Surveillance System respondents ages 25–54. We calculated the unadjusted prevalence and adjusted prevalence ratios to compare employed workers to respondents who were self-employed, short-term (<12 months) unemployed, long-term unemployed, and unable to work.

Results: Adverse health outcomes increased with unemployment duration and were highest for those unable to work. Non-Hispanic Blacks were most likely to be unemployed or unable to work. Short-term unemployment and self-employment were associated with poor healthcare access. Health behaviors and outcomes declined with increasing duration of unemployment and were worst for those unable to work.

Conclusions: In the United States, access to affordable healthcare is problematic for both the self-employed and the short-term unemployed. Short-term unemployment is a particularly important locus for intervention and provision of resources to prevent health declines that may hinder re-employment.

KEYWORDS
employment status, health equity, healthcare access, occupational health, unemployment

1 | INTRODUCTION

While unemployment has been associated with poor health, comprehensive assessments of associations among employment status influence work options and, therefore, occupational exposures. Work affects health not only via adverse and positive workplace physical and psychosocial exposures but also through employment compensation and benefits, including healthcare access.